another, I would be successful in cricket ... somehow. There was, however, no clear way forward; there was never a grand plan. Most of the time, I did not have much idea what would happen next.

In effect, after leaving school, my career moved into the fast lane, and cars travelling at higher speeds are far more likely to crash because drivers have less time to identify what is happening around them and less time to react to danger. The safety margin is removed and what might normally have been a near miss can become a serious accident. Somehow, in 2003 and 2004, I managed to stay on the road.

There are many talented 18-year-olds who leave school with dreams of playing international sport, but few realise that ambition.

What separates the few from the many?

Some will say that, in almost every case, it is luck ... the luck of being selected for the right team at the right time, of performing well when it really matters, of being noticed by the people whose opinion really counts. No matter how gifted you may be, the argument runs, you need at least a little luck to get the breaks and reach the top.

Others will say it is hard work ... being prepared to practise harder and longer than others, to make more sacrifices, to get an early night when your friends are out and about so you can be fitter and sharper at practice the next morning, essentially to want the prize more desperately than other talented youngsters vying for the same place.

There were certainly one or two moments when luck played its part, when the breaks went my way, and it's also true that I have always enjoyed, even relished, the hard work and long practices, although, to be absolutely honest, in the first few years of my career, there were not many times when I felt it was necessary to miss the party.

Everything just happened.

After leaving high school at Affies, I followed the well-trodden path across Lynnwood Road to the University of Pretoria, to study Sports Science. The course included an Anatomy module, which I particularly